

Earn context before prescribing a portfolio

Days 0-30 | Replace assumptions with an operating picture

Day-120 outcomes

- Shared direction tied to business objectives, employee experience and decision rights.
- Visible portfolio of current use, proposed work, owners, dependencies, risk and status.
- Two bounded workflows commissioned with explicit authority, enablement and evidence.
- Practical CoE, ambassadors, scorecard and pilot-to-pattern playbook.

First-week listening agenda

- Align with the executive sponsor on expectations, decision rights and success narrative.
- Meet IT, Data, Security, HR, Legal, Finance, Procurement, Operations, Sales and Customer Service leaders.
- Observe frontline systems, handoffs, workarounds and informal support.
- Ask for one valuable workflow, one feared failure and one change employees adopted well.

Questions to answer

- Which workflows constrain growth, customer service, margin, capacity or employee experience?
- What tools, data, vendors, support paths, legal boundaries and security requirements already exist?
- Where are curiosity, rational fear, confidence, unequal access and change fatigue?
- How are usage, quality, risk, value and employee confidence currently measured?

Day-30 decision

- Agree on two bounded workflows to commission, their owners, evidence, support model and explicit out-of-scope boundaries.

Use bounded work to prove the adoption mechanism

Days 31-90 | Select, design, operate and learn

Days 31-60

- Prioritize two workflows using value, owner commitment, context/data readiness, risk, adoption burden and reuse potential.
- Complete the Job Signal / Context + Data / AI Role / Human Authority / Proof + Reuse review.
- Define user journey, source context, checkpoints, exceptions, support, evaluation and rollback.
- Recruit trusted users and managers; practice with real cases before launch.

Days 61-90

- Run a weekly pilot decision review with business owner, IT/Data, risk partners and adoption lead.
- Provide office hours, manager reinforcement, examples and escalation.
- Log corrections, overrides, abandonment, recurring questions, workarounds and reusable components.

Pilot scorecard

- Workflow result: cycle time, rework, backlog, service, capacity or decision quality.
- Trust and control: evaluation, correction, override, escalation and auditability.
- Adoption: eligible use, depth, abandonment, workarounds and support demand.
- Capability: confidence, clarity of limits, access to help and equitable access.
- Reuse: stable data, known failure modes, support owner and reusable components.

Communication cadence

- Executive sponsor update every two weeks; owner decision review weekly; office hours weekly; ambassador learning circle biweekly; employee communication tied to real work and explicit limits.

Day-90 disposition

- Scale when evidence supports wider use; repair when value remains but fit is weak; hold when readiness is insufficient; stop or keep human-led when AI does not justify the change burden.

Turn pilot learning into an operating system

Days 91-120 | Install enterprise capability

Practical Center of Excellence

- Provide use-case intake and fit review, responsible-use patterns, evaluation support, vendor/platform coordination, reusable assets and portfolio transparency.
- Operate as an enabling core, not a gatekeeping bureaucracy. Business owners remain accountable for workflows and outcomes.

Ambassador and enablement system

- Recruit trusted, role-diverse ambassadors with protected learning time and direct feedback channels.
- Create foundation, workflow practitioner, owner/approver and builder/support learning paths.
- Equip managers with conversation guides, examples, limits, reinforcement and escalation.

Executive portfolio scorecard

- Report workflow value, quality and trust, appropriate reliance, adoption depth, confidence, equitable access, support demand, reuse and learning speed.

Decision rights

- Functional leaders own business outcome and workflow change.
- IT/Data owns platform, integration and support.
- Legal/Security/HR own responsible-use and employee-impact boundaries.
- Executive portfolio forum owns scale, repair, hold and stop investment decisions.

Day-120 executive review

- What changed in the work, and what evidence remains incomplete?
- Where did employee skepticism expose a real design problem?
- Which components, controls and enablement patterns are reusable?
- Which use cases should enter the next fit review?
- What team shape, vendor posture and investment are justified?
- What should remain explicitly out of scope?

12-month horizon

- AI adoption becomes a visible operating discipline: business-owned, technically supported, responsibly governed, role-enabled and measured by outcomes plus employee confidence.